

Least Flycatcher (*Empidonax minimus*) probable nesting, Mesa County Colorado

On May 26, 2007 about 12:00 noon James Beatty and Peter Derven observed probable nesting of a pair of Least Flycatchers in Connected Lakes Park, Grand Junction, Mesa County, CO. The habitat is predominantly Western Cottonwood riparian with mixed deciduous shrubbery understory. From the first parking lot after passing through the pay station, we walked a concrete pathway paralleling a river (canal?) to the first major path on the right (perhaps 300 yards), also concrete paved at first, then gravel toward a kiosk of some sort. Before reaching the kiosk, one might begin hearing the birds. The nest in a clump of smaller cottonwoods, as described below, is on the north side of the gravel path.

We were first alerted to the presence of Least Flycatchers by their distinctive "Che-bek" calls. At first just one called about 6 or 8 times and stopped for about 5 minutes before repeating another 6 or 8 "che-beks." This pattern continued as Jim and I circled through the cottonwood grove eventually obtaining visual confirmation of a typical empid: olive above with no color contrast between slightly-crested head and back, two bold white wingbars on blackish wings, a very noticeable thin white eye-ring, a large-headed, small-billed impression, yellowish mandible, white throat and a flush of palest olive on the upper breast, a faint flush of yellowish on the flanks and calling "che-bek" throughout the frontal visual encounter.

One bird then flew into a group of about a dozen smaller cottonwoods, trunks averaging 8 to 12 inches in diameter, landed about 30 - 35 feet high near the trunk at an apparent nest located where a major side-branch, perhaps 2 -3 inches in diameter made a crotch with the main trunk. I realized it was a nest; the bird entered the small twiggy structure, sidled down moving side to side as if molding the cup to its body-shape, then almost immediately left the nest to perch a few inches away facing me and resumed the "che-bek" calls.

At this time we heard a second bird return the "che-bek" calls from across the trail while observing the first bird near the nest. Certainly two birds were present, and almost certainly they were attempting to nest.

We continued to witness and ascertain the presence of two Least Flycatcher for several more minutes both visually and aurally. When we returned to our vehicle, Jim called Larry Semo on his cell phone to report our sighting and solicit back-up confirmation.

Both Jim and I are observers with 30+ years experience each; we are very familiar with Least Flycatchers in our previous home areas, he in Ohio and I in New York's Hudson Valley.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Peter Derven', written in a cursive style.

Peter Derven

5/27/07